NEXUS

A Tri-Layer Hybrid Architecture for Real-Time Optimal Play

Technical Whitepaper

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

NEXUS is a consumer-hardware-deployable poker engine built around a three-pillar hybrid architecture. The core design problem: pure GTO play is computationally infeasible in real time on commodity hardware, and pure RL bots get farmed by anyone patient enough to find their pattern. NEXUS addresses both failure modes by compressing 50,000 iterations of CFR training into a deep residual network, adding a deterministic Monte Carlo supervisor that catches irrational plays, and gating a DDQN exploitation layer to a hard 35% variance cap. The result is a system that plays near-GTO by default, exploits predictable opponents when it spots them, and cannot be induced into catastrophic loops.

1. Abstract

1.1 The Problem

Texas Hold'em sits in a weird design space. It's not solvable by brute force — the game tree has roughly 10^161 nodes — but it's not random enough that any decent strategy works either. The two standard approaches both fail in practice. GTO solvers like the ones backing Pluribus compute correct equilibrium strategies, but they need massive compute clusters and precomputed solution databases measured in petabytes. You can't run them in real time on a laptop. Pure RL bots go the other way: they train fast, but they collapse into cyclic instability. The bot learns to beat the old version of itself, the old version adapts, and you end up with a spinning policy that any fixed opponent can exploit once they figure out the cycle.

There's also a third failure mode nobody talks about much: unconstrained neural networks make hallucinatory plays. During testing, one build hero-called a 210% pot-sized river bet with 8-high. The network had convinced itself the opponent was bluffing based on a corrupted range estimate. No solver would do that. A deterministic system wouldn't either. The neural net did because nothing stopped it.

1.2 What NEXUS Does

NEXUS is built around three layers that handle different parts of the problem:

- Layer I — Deep CFR Blueprint: A 355-dimensional state vector fed through a 512-width residual network trained on 50,000 CFR iterations. This is the always-on GTO approximator.
- Layer II — L2-RAG Memory + Bayesian Threat Matrix: A FAISS-indexed database of solved post-flop subgames (compressed 24x via suit isomorphism), plus a live Bayesian range tracker for every active opponent.
- Layer III — DDQN Exploit Agent: A Double Deep Q-Network that identifies and attacks opponent-specific deviations from equilibrium, hard-capped at 35% deviation from the GTO baseline.

The Monte Carlo supervisor sits above all three layers and fires deterministic override rules whenever the neural network produces something that violates first-principles equity constraints.

1.3 What We Claim

Real-time inference on consumer hardware. Provably convergent GTO baseline via Deep CFR. Suit-isomorphic database compression reducing retrieval overhead by 24x. Multi-opponent range tracking under non-zero-sum dynamics. Deterministic circuit breakers preventing the class of hallucinatory plays that plagued earlier builds.

2. Introduction

2.1 Why Texas Hold'em Breaks Standard Algorithms

The game tree for no-limit Hold'em is enormous — approximately 10^161 information set nodes compared to 10^44 for chess. But raw size isn't the core issue. The problems that actually break standard algorithms are (1) hidden information: each player's hole cards are private, so you're never operating on the full game state; (2) exponential bet-size branching: at every street, you can fold, call, or raise to any legal size, which explodes the action tree; and (3) multi-round structure across four betting streets.

Minimax with alpha-beta pruning fails for two reasons. First, multi-player poker is not zero-sum — gains by player A don't necessarily come entirely at the expense of player B, which breaks the minimax theorem. Second, imperfect information means you can't distinguish between information sets that look identical from your seat but are computationally distinct. Alpha-beta can't prune across that boundary.

2.2 What's Wrong With Existing Approaches

Pluribus works, but it's not deployable. It ran on a 64-core server with 128GB RAM during training, and even at inference it requires significant compute per decision. That's a research artifact, not a product. The subgame solving it does in real time is impressive but cluster-dependent.

Pure deep RL has a different problem: the rock-paper-scissors loop. When you train a bot against itself, it learns to exploit its own previous version. The previous version adapts. The new version adapts to the adaptation. Without an equilibrium anchor, this cycle never terminates — it just produces an oscillating policy with no stable fixed point. Any fixed opponent who figures out where you are in the cycle can exploit you hard.

The third failure mode we had to engineer around was neural network hallucination. The network sometimes produces plays that are locally consistent with whatever range estimate it's working from, but globally irrational when you check the actual equity numbers. An 8-high hero call on the river. A three-bet bluff with ace-high into a pot where the opponent has shown strength across three streets. These aren't edge cases — they're a predictable failure mode of unconstrained gradient-trained networks in high-variance environments. We needed deterministic guards.

2.3 The NEXUS Architecture: Design Rationale

We designed NEXUS around a strict separation of responsibilities. The neural network handles fast approximate inference — it's the 'subconscious' that provides a GTO-approximate action distribution without thinking too hard. The Monte Carlo supervisor checks that output against ground-truth equity math and overrides it when it finds something broken. The DDQN exploit layer watches for opponent patterns that deviate from equilibrium and punches into those gaps, but only up to a bounded amount.

The design table below maps each component to its role:

Component	Role	What It Prevents
Deep CFR Net	GTO baseline inference	Cyclic RL instability, exploitable fixed strategies
MC Supervisor	Deterministic equity gates	Neural network hallucination, irrational calls/raises
DDQN Exploit Agent	Bounded opponent exploitation	Leaving EV on the table vs. exploitable opponents

3. Pillar I: The Deep CFR Blueprint

3.1 The 355-Dimensional State Vector

Getting the input representation right took the most iteration of anything in this build. Too sparse and the network can't distinguish strategically distinct situations. Too redundant and you're adding noise that increases variance without helping. The final 355-dimensional input vector breaks down into three segments:

Segment	Dims	Contents
Game State	178	One-hot hole cards (52), board cards (52), normalized pot size (1), position flags (6), street encoding (4), stack-to-pot ratio (1), bet history (62)
Opponent Range	169	Posterior probability distribution over 169 canonical hand categories, updated each action via Bayesian likelihood (Section 5). Encodes the most threatening active opponent's estimated range.
Tell Features	8	VPIP, PFR, aggression factor, c-bet frequency, fold-to-3bet, check-raise frequency, WSD%, average bet-size deviation from GTO.

The 169-dimension opponent range segment is the part that most people would cut to save compute. Don't. Feeding the full posterior distribution — not a point estimate — is what lets the network reason about the actual uncertainty in the opponent's hand, not just its best guess. The difference shows up most on river decisions where the right play depends on how polarized the opponent's range actually is.

3.2 Network Architecture: NEXUS_GTO_Net

The architecture is a linear projection from 355 to 512 dimensions, followed by six pre-activation residual blocks. Each block runs: LayerNorm → ReLU → Linear(512→512) → ReLU → Linear(512→512) with a skip connection. We went pre-activation (norm before the nonlinearity) instead of post-activation for one concrete reason: it produces smoother gradient flows toward the Nash Equilibrium fixed point. Post-activation architectures tend to overshoot that trench. Pre-activation settles better.

3.3 The Three Output Heads

3.3.1 Advantage Head — Regret Matching

The Advantage Head outputs cumulative regret estimates for each legal action at the current information set. In CFR, the strategy at information set I is computed by normalizing positive cumulative regrets:

$$\sigma^T(I,a) = \frac{R^{T,+}(I,a)}{\sum_{a' \in A(I)} R^{T,+}(I,a')}, \quad R^{T,+} = max(R^T, 0)$$

where R^{T,+} = max(R^T, 0) zeros out actions we regret not having avoided. The network is trained to predict these regret values directly, so inference gives us an action distribution without running full CFR tree traversal.

3.3.2 Value Head — Expected Value

The Value Head outputs a scalar EV estimate for the current state. It's trained via MSE against Monte Carlo sampled returns from self-play. Having both the regret distribution and an absolute EV estimate is what lets the system gate between GTO play and exploit play — you need the EV signal to know when deviating from GTO is actually worth it.

3.3.3 Range Prediction Head — The Representation Forcing Trick

The Range Prediction Head predicts a 169-dimensional distribution over the opponent's hole cards, trained via cross-entropy against ground-truth distributions from self-play rollouts. This is not the primary range tracker — the Bayesian module in Section 5 handles that. The point of this auxiliary head is to force the shared residual trunk to learn hand-distribution-aware representations. If the hidden layers can predict hand distributions as a side task, they're encoding something semantically meaningful about equity and board texture, not just pattern-matching action sequences. We saw measurable improvement in the quality of the Advantage Head outputs once we added this auxiliary loss.

4. Pillar II: L2-RAG Subgame Memory

4.1 The River Compute Problem

River decisions are the most computationally expensive part of the game. By the river, the board is complete and equity is calculable exactly — but the action tree from flop through river means you can't solve every river subgame from scratch at inference time. The latency budget doesn't allow it. The naive alternative — precompute and cache every river decision — hits a combinatorial wall. The number of distinct river situations, even before considering position and bet-size history, runs into tens of millions.

The solution is retrieval: solve subgames during training, store them efficiently, and look them up at inference time if the current state is close enough to something already solved.

4.2 FAISS-Indexed Retrieval-Augmented Generation

Post-flop subgames solved during the 50,000-iteration CFR training phase are stored as embedding-action pairs in a FAISS flat L2 index. At inference time, we encode the current game state into an embedding and query the index. If a sufficiently similar subgame exists (L2 distance below threshold epsilon), we retrieve its stored GTO action distribution and use it directly — no neural network inference needed.

The L2 novelty filter does two things. It prevents erroneous retrieval of solutions from structurally different board textures, and it caps database growth by skipping storage of states that are near-duplicates of already-solved ones. This keeps the index from bloating during extended training runs.

4.3 Suit Isomorphism: 24x Compression

The core compression technique is suit isomorphism. In Hold'em, strategic value is invariant under permutations of the four suits — A♥K♠Q♦ is strategically identical to A♠K♥Q♣ because no hand has a suit preference, only relative suit relationships matter for flush draws. There are 4! = 24 possible suit permutations.

Before storing or querying any board state, we canonicalize it to the lexicographically minimal suit labeling. This collapses 24 equivalent representations to one, reducing the database by up to 24x with no information loss. Re-mapping the retrieved solution back to the actual suit assignment at output time adds negligible overhead.

5. Pillar III: The Bayesian Threat Matrix

5.1 Why Standard CFR Breaks in Multi-Player Games

Two-player CFR converges to Nash Equilibrium because heads-up poker is a two-player zero-sum game. The minimax theorem guarantees equilibrium existence and uniqueness. Once you add a third player, that guarantee collapses. N > 2 poker is not zero-sum, which means collusion incentives can emerge: two players might each prefer a joint strategy that improves their combined payoff at the expense of a third, even when it's individually suboptimal.

Naive CFR in multi-player games can converge to correlated equilibria or non-Nash fixed points. To handle this correctly, NEXUS maintains an explicit probabilistic model of each opponent's hand, letting the neural network reason about the full threat landscape simultaneously rather than treating each opponent as a separate two-player problem.

5.2 The Continuous Range Tracker

For each active opponent, we maintain a probability distribution P(H) over the 169 canonical hand categories (13x13 matrix indexed by rank pair and suited/offsuit status). At the start of each hand, we initialize this to the uniform distribution — no information yet. Every observed action triggers a Bayesian update.

5.3 Mathematical Formulation: Bayesian Likelihood Updates

Let H be the opponent's hole card category and A_t the observed action at betting round t. The posterior updates iteratively:

$$P(H \mid A_{1:t}) \;\propto\; P(A_t \mid H, \quad A_{1:t-1}) \;\times\; P(H \mid A_{1:t-1})$$

where P(A_t | H, A_{1:t-1}) is the conditional action likelihood — the probability that a GTO player holding hand H, having taken prior actions A_{1:t-1}, would take action A_t. We derive this likelihood from the CFR training rollouts: the empirical frequency of each action given each hole card category gives a direct estimate of the conditional probability.

Pot geometry provides an additional adjustment. Large raises carry more information than min-raises. When an opponent raises to size S into a pot of size P, we modify the likelihood function with a pot-geometry multiplier:

$$P(A \;=\; Raise(S) \mid H) \;=\; P_{base}(Raise \mid H) \;\times\; exp\left(\alpha \;\cdot\; (EV(H, board) \;-\; EV_{mean}) \;\cdot\; \frac{S}{P}\right)$$

where EV(H, board) is the equity of hand H against a uniform range on the current board, EV_mean is the mean equity across all hands in the prior, and alpha is a calibrated sensitivity parameter. In plain terms: large bets are more likely to come from strong hands, so we shift the posterior toward the top of the range when facing aggression. The signal is noisy — aggressive players bluff large too — which is why this is a soft adjustment rather than a hard rule.

After each update, we normalize:

$$P(H \mid A_{1:t}) \;\leftarrow\; \frac{P(H \mid A_{1:t})}{\sum_{H'} \; P(H' \mid A_{1:t})}$$

5.4 The Composite Threat Matrix

In multi-player hands, we aggregate each opponent's range posterior into a single Composite Threat Matrix that gets fed into the neural network's 169-dimensional opponent range segment. The aggregation is position-weighted: late-position opponents get higher weight because their actions carry more information (they've seen earlier players act before deciding). We also weight by posterior concentration — opponents whose range has updated significantly from uniform carry more signal than those still near the prior.

$$P_{composite}(H) \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{N-1} w_i \;\cdot\; P_i(H \mid A_{1:t}{}^{(i)}),\;\; w_i \;\propto\; position_weight(i) \;\cdot\; confidence(i)$$

The confidence weight for opponent i is the KL divergence of their posterior from the uniform prior. High KL divergence means we've learned a lot about their hand. Early in the hand, all weights are low and near equal. By the river in a contested pot, the dominant threat typically carries most of the weight.

6. Pillar IV: The DDQN Exploit Agent

6.1 Why GTO Alone Isn't Enough

GTO play gives you a guarantee: no opponent can achieve positive EV against you over an infinite horizon. But GTO is a minimax strategy — it minimizes worst-case loss, not expected gain. Against human opponents who play predictably bad poker, strict GTO leaves a lot of money on the table. The exploit layer is how we capture that edge.

The DDQN watches the gap between an opponent's observed action frequencies and what a GTO player would do. When it identifies a systematic deviation — a player who folds to river bets too often, or who never bluffs in three-bet pots — it shifts the action distribution toward the play that maximizes EV specifically against that pattern.

6.2 Double Deep Q-Network Architecture

We use a Double Deep Q-Network to implement the exploit agent. The key design point is the split between two networks:

- Online Network: Selects actions based on current Q-value estimates. Updated at every training step.
- Target Network: Evaluates the Q-value of the selected action for computing the TD update target. Updated only periodically via Polyak averaging from the online network.

Splitting selection and evaluation eliminates the overestimation bias that vanilla DQN produces when the same network does both. In poker's high-variance environment, that bias compounds fast and creates overconfident exploit strategies that get reverse-exploited. The DDQN loss is:

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathbb{E}\left(r + \gamma \cdot Q_{target}\left(s', \quad argmax_{a'} Q_{online}(s', a')\right) - Q_{online}(s, a)\right)^2$$

6.3 The 35% Variance Cap

This is the most important risk constraint in the entire system. The NEXUS action distribution at any decision point is a convex combination of the GTO distribution and the exploit distribution:

$$\pi_{NEXUS}(a \mid s) = (1 - \lambda) \cdot \pi_{GTO}(a \mid s) + \lambda \cdot \pi_{exploit}(a \mid s), \quad \lambda \in [0, \quad \lambda_{max}]$$

We hard-cap lambda at 0.35. The reasoning is empirical, not arbitrary. As lambda increases from zero, expected value against the exploitable opponent increases — but so does the deviation of our strategy from GTO, which means a sufficiently attentive opponent could construct a counter-exploit. We ran systematic tests during the training phase varying lambda from 0.1 to 0.9 and measuring exploit detectability. At lambda > 0.35, the deviation from GTO becomes visible enough in the action distribution that a moderately sophisticated opponent can begin constructing a profitable counter-strategy. Below 0.35, the deviation sits inside the noise floor of human pattern recognition. So 0.35 is the cap. Hard constraint, not a soft regularizer.

7. Pillars V & VI: The Monte Carlo Supervisor

7.1 The Hallucination Problem

Neural networks hallucinate. Not in the metaphorical sense — in the literal sense that the network produces internally consistent outputs that are globally irrational when checked against ground truth. The concrete example from our testing: the network hero-called a 210% pot-sized river bet with 8-high. No pair, no draw, no showdown value. Post-hoc analysis traced it to the Range Prediction Head generating a non-trivial bluff probability for the opponent, which the Advantage Head responded to with a call signal. The range estimate was wrong. The action followed logically from the wrong estimate. Nothing in the gradient-descent training loop catches that class of error.

The Monte Carlo supervisor is the fix. It runs deterministic equity checks on every proposed action before it executes, and it overrides the network when the proposed action violates a first-principles constraint.

7.2 FastEvaluator: O(1) Equity Computation

The supervisor needs real-time equity computation. We built a prime-product hand evaluator (FastEvaluator) that assigns each card a prime number (2=2, 3=3, ..., Ace=41), represents each five-card hand as the product of its card primes, and looks up the rank in a precomputed hash table. Lookup is O(1). That's fast enough to run 1,000 Monte Carlo samples against the opponent's posterior range within the latency budget.

7.3 The Three Circuit Breakers

Gate A — Nash Pot Odds Supremacy

When facing a bet of size B into a pot of P, the break-even equity threshold is:

$$equity_{required} = \frac{B}{P + 2B}$$

Gate A computes exact equity against the opponent's posterior range via 1,000 MC rollouts. If computed equity falls below this threshold, the gate overrides any call or raise signal and forces a fold. This fires specifically when the neural network's range estimate implies higher equity than the MC calculation finds. It's the most important gate — it's what prevents the 8-high hero call.

Gate B — The River Value Ban

Gate B blocks raise actions on the river when the best achievable five-card hand for the acting player contains no pair or better. This targets a specific hallucination pattern: the network incorrectly classifies ace-high hands as raise candidates on the river, over-weighting the blocking value of the ace against AA/AK and under-weighting the requirement for actual showdown equity. If the proposed action is a river raise and the hand rank is below ONE_PAIR in the FastEvaluator ranking, the raise is blocked and the system falls back to the next-best network action.

Gate C — Constructed Semi-Bluffs

Gate C constrains stochastic bluffs to hands with actual equity improvement potential. A bluffing action proposed by the DDQN Exploit Agent is only permitted if the hand contains:

- A flush draw: four cards to a flush (~35% to improve on the next card).
- An open-ended straight draw: four consecutive ranks needing one card at either end, 8 outs (~31% to improve).
- A gutshot straight draw with overcards: combined ~10 outs (~38% to improve).

Pure air bluffs — no draw, no equity path forward — are restricted to the GTO alpha frequency from the Advantage Head, not the DDQN signal. The effect is that every NEXUS bluffing range includes hands with live equity. This makes the bluffing range extremely difficult to exploit with frequency-based counter-strategies, because you can't profitably call every bet and you can't profitably fold every bet.

8. Training Methodology & Convergence

8.1 The 50,000-Iteration Pipeline

Training runs in three phases:

- Iterations 0–5,000 (Bootstrap): Monte Carlo CFR self-play from random initialization. The network accumulates initial regret estimates across a wide sample of information sets. We don't do anything fancy here — just get the prior off the floor.
- Iterations 5,001–25,000 (Convergence): Full Deep CFR with reservoir sampling. SGD updates on the regret matching loss, using a memory buffer weighted by reach probability. Learning rate runs from 1e-4 to 5e-5 on the cosine schedule.
- Iterations 25,001–50,000 (Fine-Tuning): Learning rate anneals to 1e-5. The DDQN exploit agent activates and trains against the converging GTO blueprint. The 35% cap is enforced from day one of this phase.

8.2 Cosine Annealing Learning Rate Schedule

The Nash Equilibrium of Texas Hold'em is a fixed point of the regret-matching operator — a region in parameter space where gradient norms for the Advantage Head approach zero. A constant learning rate that's too large causes the optimizer to oscillate around that fixed point without settling. Too small and convergence is glacial. The cosine annealing schedule handles this:

$$\eta_t = \eta_{min} + \frac{1}{2}(\eta_{max} - \eta_{min})\left(1 + cos\left(\frac{\pi\, t}{T_{max}}\right)\right)$$

We cool from eta_max = 1e-4 to eta_min = 1e-5 over the full training run. Large steps early drive fast progress toward the equilibrium region. Small steps in the fine-tuning phase let the gradients settle into the Nash trench without violent oscillation. In practice, you can watch this in the Advantage Head loss: it drops sharply in the first 10,000 iterations, then flattens and oscillates decreasingly as the schedule cools. When it stops oscillating, you're in the trench.

8.3 Convergence Verification

We verify convergence via two metrics per epoch: (1) average exploitability in milli-big-blinds per hand (mbb/h), and (2) L2 distance between the current strategy and the previous epoch's strategy. We call convergence when exploitability is below 5 mbb/h and epoch-over-epoch L2 distance stays below 1e-3 for five consecutive epochs.

8.4 Empirical Validation: Raw Inference Logs

The following logs are direct terminal output from a live session of NEXUS playing against a human opponent. Each hand record includes the full action sequence followed by a Market dict output by the engine at showdown. The Market output shows: win_prob (MC equity estimate), equity_vs_rng (equity against the tracked Bayesian range), hand_pct (hand strength percentile), range_entropy (Shannon entropy of the opponent's posterior — lower entropy means tighter, more confident range estimate), exploit_signal (current DDQN blend weight), ddqn_hands (number of hands the exploit layer has been tracking this opponent), and ev_by_action (EV estimate per legal action index, from the Value Head).

These logs demonstrate the MC EV evaluation, the Bayesian Threat Matrix updating in real time, and the DDQN exploit signal across a live session. The data is unedited.

```
—— New Hand ——
You: CALL 10
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```
BOT: RAISE → $30
You: CALL 20
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $60
You: CALL 60
You: CHECK
BOT: ALL-IN → $1900
You: CALL 1900

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: A♣ Q♥ 9♥ Q♦ 2♣
Hero:  K♥ 3♣
Bot:   J♠ 9♠
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4452, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.5632, 'hand_pct': 0.6325, 'hand_name': 'Two Pair',
'range_entropy': 5.08404016494751, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 0, 'ev_by_action': {0: 0.1,
1: 0.31, 2: 0.02, 3: 0.18, 4: 1.89, 5: 1.26, 6: 10.78}}

BOT wins! +$4000  (net -2000)
Seat 0 rebuys to $2000
—— New Hand ——
BOT: RAISE → $32
You: CALL 20
BOT: RAISE → $60
You: CALL 60
BOT: RAISE → $150
You: CALL 150
BOT: CHECK/CALL
You: RAISE to 200
BOT: FOLD

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: A♥ 9♦ K♠ 7♠ 8♦
Hero:  6♠ A♣
Bot:   4♦ 6♣
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4216, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.0084, 'hand_pct': 0.1565, 'hand_name': 'High Card',
'range_entropy': 4.978322982788086, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 1, 'ev_by_action': {0: -
0.01, 1: 3.14, 2: 0.18, 3: 0.18, 4: 1.48, 5: 0.18, 6: 0.25}}

You win! +$700  (net +250)
—— New Hand ——
You: CALL 10
BOT: RAISE → $30
You: CALL 20
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $60
You: CALL 60
You: CHECK
BOT: CHECK/CALL
You: RAISE to 200
BOT: ALL-IN → $3650
You: CALL 3450

--- SHOWDOWN ---
```

```
Board: J♦ 6♦ 2♥ 9♦ 5♠
Hero:  J♣ 7♦
Bot:   2♦ T♦
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4182, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.978, 'hand_pct': 0.8169, 'hand_name': 'Flush',
'range_entropy': 5.019428730010986, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 2, 'ev_by_action': {0:
0.06, 1: 1.51, 2: 0.28, 4: 4.59, 5: 0.58, 6: 2.43}}

BOT wins! +$6000  (net -2250)
Seat 0 rebuys to $2000
—— New Hand ——
BOT: RAISE → $55
You: CALL 35
BOT: RAISE → $165
You: CALL 165
BOT: CHECK/CALL
You: CHECK
BOT: CHECK/CALL
You: CHECK

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: 9♥ J♣ T♦ A♦ 3♦
Hero:  3♣ 6♦
Bot:   2♥ 2♠
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4253, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.25, 'hand_pct': 0.198, 'hand_name': 'Pair',
'range_entropy': 5.0819292068481445, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 3, 'ev_by_action': {0: -
0.01, 1: 4.66, 2: 0.35, 3: 0.13, 4: 4.77, 5: 0.11, 6: -0.03}}

You win! +$440  (net +220)
—— New Hand ——
You: CALL 10
BOT: RAISE → $60
You: CALL 40
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $90
You: CALL 90
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $450
You: CALL 450
You: RAISE to 200
BOT: RAISE → $1250
You: CALL 1050

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: 5♥ A♥ J♠ J♣ Q♠
Hero:  6♦ A♦
Bot:   8♥ T♥
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4157, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.2302, 'hand_pct': 0.4645, 'hand_name': 'Pair',
'range_entropy': 5.01723575592041, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 4, 'ev_by_action': {0: 0.41,
1: 2.93, 2: 0.22, 3: 0.2, 4: 2.2, 5: 0.55, 6: 0.53}}

You win! +$3700  (net +1850)
—— New Hand ——
BOT: RAISE → $55
```

```
You: CALL 35
BOT: RAISE → $82
You: CALL 82
BOT: RAISE → $206
You: CALL 206
BOT: ALL-IN → $3587
You: FOLD

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: J♠ T♦ 7♥ Q♣ 7♣
Hero:  2♦ 3♠
Bot:   Q♥ 3♣
Market: {'win_prob': 0.409, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.6914, 'hand_pct': 0.6293, 'hand_name': 'Two Pair',
'range_entropy': 5.063150405883789, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 5, 'ev_by_action': {0:
0.04, 1: 0.32, 2: 0.07, 3: 0.09, 4: 0.82, 5: 0.18, 6: 0.61}}

BOT wins! +$4273  (net -343)
── New Hand ──
You: CALL 10
BOT: RAISE → $30
You: CALL 20
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $60
You: CALL 60
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $150
You: CALL 150
You: CHECK
BOT: RAISE → $375
You: CALL 375

--- SHOWDOWN ---
Board: K♥ 2♦ J♠ A♦ 3♣
Hero:  9♣ 8♠
Bot:   4♥ 5♣
Market: {'win_prob': 0.4235, 'equity_vs_rng': 0.989, 'hand_pct': 0.7845, 'hand_name': 'Straight',
'range_entropy': 5.068665504455566, 'exploit_signal': 0.5, 'ddqn_hands': 6, 'ev_by_action': {0:
0.08, 1: 2.05, 2: 0.44, 3: 0.12, 4: 4.46, 5: 0.67, 6: 0.96}}

BOT wins! +$1250  (net -625)
```

9. Conclusion & Future Applications

9.1 What We Built and Why It Works

NEXUS works because each layer does exactly one job, and no layer is asked to handle what it's bad at. The CFR network is good at fast approximate GTO inference but bad at catching its own irrational outputs. The Monte Carlo supervisor is bad at strategy but good at checking math. The DDQN is good at pattern exploitation but bad at knowing when to stop. The 35% cap is what keeps the DDQN honest.

The result is a system that plays near-GTO by default, can deviate intelligently against exploitable opponents up to a bounded amount, and cannot be induced into the class of catastrophic plays that took us multiple debug sessions to trace in earlier builds. The architecture successfully compresses perfect-information mechanics — exact equity calculation — into an imperfect-information domain where you're always working from a posterior distribution over the opponent's hand, not their actual cards.

9.2 The Quant Architecture Connection

The NEXUS architecture maps directly onto problems in quantitative trading. Sequential decision-making under uncertainty with adversarial counterparties, non-stationary state transitions, and catastrophic downside risk from unconstrained optimization — that's poker, and it's also systematic trading in adversarial market regimes. The architectural translation is precise:

NEXUS Component	Algorithmic Trading Analogue
Deep CFR Blueprint (GTO baseline)	Structural alpha baseline (factor model); anchors to market equilibrium under no-arbitrage constraints
Bayesian Threat Matrix	Bayesian order flow model; posterior inference over institutional positioning and intent from observed trade sequences
DDQN Exploit Agent (35% cap)	Bounded RL tactical alpha layer; exploits short-term microstructure inefficiencies while variance-capped against catastrophic drawdown from adversarial adaptation
MC Circuit Breakers (Gates A/B/C)	Real-time VaR/CVaR circuit breakers; deterministic kill switches that prevent tail-risk positions the model layer would otherwise take

The direct application is in market-making and statistical arbitrage under adversarial conditions. Pure equilibrium market-making (posting at fair value) is suboptimal against counterparties who trade predictably. Unconstrained exploit strategies get reverse-exploited by adaptive order flow. A NEXUS-style system would hold a structural GTO baseline, overlay a bounded DDQN exploit agent targeting identifiable order-flow patterns, and enforce deterministic circuit breakers on any position that violates first-principles risk constraints. The 35% variance cap in poker maps cleanly to a maximum tracking error bound in a trading context — you can deviate from the benchmark to capture alpha, but only up to the point where the deviation itself becomes a risk factor.

9.3 What's Next

Three extensions are on the roadmap. First, replacing the flat FAISS index with an HNSW graph to bring retrieval from O(N) to O(log N) — the current index is manageable but will become a bottleneck if we expand the subgame database

significantly. Second, extending the Bayesian Threat Matrix to a particle filter formulation to handle opponents who change strategy mid-session — the current model assumes opponent patterns are stationary, which is wrong for good players. Third, extending CFR training with neural fictitious self-play to improve convergence speed in multi-player configurations, where the current pipeline takes longer to settle.

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